

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

TUESDAY 1 SEPTEMBER 2026



A MONTH'S QUIET ENDS OVER A STRAIT · SINGAPORE DRAWS AN AGE LINE ON THE FEED · NVIDIA'S RECORD QUARTER, AND THE CUSTOMER BUILDING A RIVAL · THE BELT YOU NEVER REPLACE · A NATION THAT FILLS ITS MALLS AND BUYS NOTHING

THE WORLD

A month's truce over Hormuz breaks in a night — the first strikes since July, and an oil lane that stays a weapon

TECHNOLOGY

Nvidia prints a ninety-six-billion-dollar quarter — and the same week, its biggest customer turns up with a chip to bench against it

THE LONG READ

Indonesia's malls have never been busier. The tills have never been quieter. A country invents a word for it

THIS ISSUE · THE WEEKDAY BOOK

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FROM THE DESK

"Reality is that which, when you stop believing in it, doesn't go away."

— Philip K. Dick, *How to Build a Universe That Doesn't Fall Apart Two Days Later* (1978)¹

Dick meant it as a working definition, half a joke, and it holds up as a test you can run on a whole issue. A government announces growth of five per cent; the malls of Jakarta fill up and the tills stay silent, and the country invents a word — *Rojali*, "the crowd that rarely buys" — for the gap between the two (p21). A capital calls a missile strike on its own soil "baseless" while the maps say otherwise (p3). A belt is sold as "genuine leather," which turns out to mean the opposite of what it says (p6). A record labelled "all-analog" was cut from a digital file for eleven years before anyone admitted it (p15). The week's real subject is the distance between the label and the thing — and the things that don't go away when you stop believing the label.

THE STRIP — AT MONDAY'S CLOSE

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL
VWRA (All-World)	~US\$195.5 ▲
Gold (spot)	~US\$4,447 ▼
Bitcoin	~US\$78.4k ▼
US 10-year	~4.72% ▲
US dollar (DXY)	~99.7 ▲
Brent crude	~US\$90.9 ▲
STI	~5,755 ▲

Levels around the Monday 31 Aug 2026 close. Oil up on the Hormuz strikes; gold and bitcoin both down as a hawkish Fed chair firms the dollar (p14). Context, not advice.²

THE WEEK IN NUMBERS

One hundred and eighty-five days. The Strait of Hormuz has now been shut to routine traffic longer than any oil chokepoint on record — and this week it drew live fire again. — **p3**

Thirteen. The minimum age Singapore proposes to enforce on six named social platforms, with autoplay and infinite scroll off by default for those under eighteen. — **p5**

Eighty per cent. The share of Australian under-sixteens still on the platforms three months after a world-first ban — the cautionary number under every age law. — **p12**

One-point-four billion dollars. What American vinyl earned in 2024 — an eighteenth straight year of growth, and forty-four million LPs against thirty-three million CDs. — **p15**

Ten million. The number of people who have left Indonesia's middle class since 2019 — even as the headline growth rate keeps printing above five per cent. — **p21**

Sixty dollars. What a one-piece full-grain belt costs — and roughly ninety-five per cent of what a three-hundred-dollar bespoke bridle belt will ever do. — **p6**

SOURCES 1. Philip K. Dick, "How to Build a Universe That Doesn't Fall Apart Two Days Later" (1978), collected in *The Shifting Realities of Philip K. Dick* (1995). 2. stockanalysis.com; TradingEconomics; growbeansprout.com (STI); Yahoo Finance — levels around the US/SG close, Mon 31 Aug 2026. Market data is context, not investment advice.

THE WORLD · IRAN & THE GULF

A Month's Quiet Ends Over the Strait, in a Single Night

American forces struck an island Iran uses to reach the Strait of Hormuz — the first exchange since July. Tehran answered with missiles at bases in Jordan and, it claimed, the UAE. Abu Dhabi called the claim on itself "baseless." Brent jumped past ninety dollars.

The pause held for about a month, and then it did not. On Sunday 30 August, US forces struck two Revolutionary Guard rocket positions on Larak Island, the speck of Iranian territory that sits inside the mouth of the Strait of Hormuz; Central Command said the Guard had been observed preparing to fire rockets carrying sea mines into the shipping lane.¹ It was the first American strike on Iran since late July, and it broke a quiet that a dozen capitals had spent the summer trying to make permanent. Iran's semi-official Tasnim agency reported two killed and two wounded on Larak.

Tehran's reply came under a name — "Punishment of the Aggressor" — and a barrage: missiles and drones at the King Hussein and Al Azraq air bases in Jordan, which Amman said it intercepted, counting eight; and a claimed strike on Al Minhad air base in the United Arab Emirates.² Treasury Secretary Bessent signalled fresh sanctions within hours; the president threatened Iran's strategic oil terminals directly. The market did the arithmetic before the diplomats did: Brent crude rose more than three per cent to about US\$90.91, its highest in weeks and up better than eight per cent on the month.³

The strait carries a fifth of the world's seaborne oil. This week it carried live fire again.

What the strike did not do is settle what happened next, and the argument over that is the second half of the night. The reader who wants a single clean map of Sunday night will not get one — and the honest desk says so rather than choosing the tidiest version.⁴

THE WASHINGTON READ

US · CNBC / WASHINGTON POST

A defensive, limited operation to stop Iran mining the world's most important oil chokepoint — narrow by design, and answered in kind. The frame is deterrence restored, not a war begun.¹

THE TEHRAN READ

TEHRAN · IRNA / IRGC

An act of aggression against Iranian soil, civilians among the dead. The Guard vowed the Larak attack would meet "a response and punishment for the aggressor," and cast the retaliation as proportionate.²

THE NON-ALIGNED READ

DOHA · AL JAZEERA

The collapse of the Hormuz-reopening diplomacy, and a fresh oil-and-inflation shock the whole region will wear. Framed as escalation with no off-ramp yet drawn.³

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRACKERS SEE

Shipping and OSINT desks read it, for now, as a violent punctuation of a managed standoff rather than the start of a spiral — the tell being that Brent moved in single digits, not in a spike. A market pricing a genuine closure of Hormuz would not stop at ninety-one dollars.

Tanker-tracking desks; CNBC live — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · ONE CLAIM THAT ISN'T STANDING UP

Before the "widening war" headlines settle, note the crack in them. The UAE defence ministry publicly called the reported strike on Al Minhad "baseless," saying it had only intercepted drones over its territorial waters. If Abu Dhabi is right, Tehran overstated the reach of its retaliation — which points to a contained tit-for-tat, not a regional fire.⁴

UAE defence ministry statement; Al Jazeera — characterised

SOURCES 1. Washington Post, 30 Aug 2026; CNBC — US strike on Larak Island, two IRGC rocket positions, first exchange since late July; Tasnim (2 killed, 2 wounded). 2. Al Jazeera; Arab News — "Punishment of the Aggressor," strikes at King Hussein/Al Azraq (Jordan; 8 intercepted) and claimed Al Minhad (UAE); IRGC statement. 3. TradingEconomics; Bloomberg — Brent ~US\$90.91, +3.2% on the day, +8.3% on the month; Hormuz ~20% of seaborne oil. 4. UAE defence ministry (Al Minhad claim "baseless"; drones intercepted over territorial waters), 31 Aug 2026 — single-authority claim, flagged.

THE WORLD • WASHINGTON & CARACAS

"The Biggest Oil Deal in History" — and the Hundred-Billion-Dollar Blank

Trump says the US has secured control of more than 65 billion barrels of Venezuelan reserves "at no cost." The number under the number is what nobody has filled in.

On Friday 28 August the president announced what he called "the biggest oil deal in world history": American majority control of more than 65 billion barrels of Venezuela's proven reserves, brokered with the interim government of Delcy Rodríguez that took office after US forces captured Nicolás Maduro in January.¹ It would, he said, "substantially lower" petrol prices, and cost the taxpayer nothing.

The reserves are real; the mechanism is not yet. Bloomberg noted the announcement "leaves a \$100 billion question unanswered" — who funds the decade of drilling, refining and repair a wrecked industry needs before a single extra barrel reaches a pump.¹ A claim of ownership is not a delivery of oil, and this week the two are being read as the same thing.

The timing is not accidental. With Hormuz shut and Brent past ninety (p3, p14), a promise of cheap Venezuelan crude is worth more politically than it is worth in the tank — a supply story to set against a supply shock, offered in barrels that will not move for years. The market treated it accordingly, pricing the strait, not the announcement.¹

65bn

BARRELS OF VENEZUELAN RESERVES THE US CLAIMS TO CONTROL — WITH THE FUNDING, TIMELINE AND OUTPUT LEFT BLANK¹

THE SCEPTIC • RESERVES ARE NOT BARRELS

A proven reserve is oil in the ground under a favourable assumption about price and cost. Venezuela's has sat mostly un-produced for a decade because the assumption failed. Announcing control of it changes the map, not the supply — and pump prices answer to supply.

Bloomberg; Time — characterised

STILL DEVELOPING — THE DELTAS, NOT THE ARCS

Hormuz, day 185. The strait's closure to routine traffic is now the longest on record, and the Larak strikes (p3) reopened it as a live theatre rather than a frozen one. The Iran–Oman waterway-governance talks are the drawn-but-unsailed off-ramp.²

Nepal–Tibet flood. The 26 August glacial-lake outburst that tore 72 km down the Trishuli valley has passed 900 dead in Nepal alone, with thousands missing and the IFRC estimating 93,000 affected; some bodies were carried as far as 240 km into India. An advance, and a grim one, on the ~750 of a week ago.³

Ukraine. Russian forces battered Kyiv for a fifth straight day, emptying some shelves after repeated warehouse strikes, while the CIA director was reported to have floated a Trump–Putin–Zelensky meeting on his Moscow trip. Thinly sourced; treat the diplomacy as developing.⁴

The through-line. Read the week's map and the same shape recurs: a claim made loudly, a reality that has not caught up to it. A strait declared reopened that is not sailed; reserves declared controlled that are not pumped; a strike declared landed that a defence ministry says never did. The wire this week is a set of announcements waiting on the world to agree.

THE CHATTER • THE ROOM, READ COLD

Analysts split neatly: one camp reads the Gulf night as the opening of a wider confrontation, the other as a bounded exchange dressed up by both sides for domestic audiences. That the two cannot yet be told apart from the outside is itself the honest state of the story.

Foreign-policy desks; Euronews bulletins — characterised

SOURCES 1. CNBC, 28 Aug 2026 (Venezuela reserves announcement); Bloomberg ("\$100 billion question"); Time — pump-price scepticism. 2. Washington Times; TradingEconomics — Hormuz closure day ~185, longest on record; Iran–Oman talks. 3. ABC News; CNN; IFRC — 2026 Nepal–Tibet glacial-lake flood, >900 dead in Nepal, ~93,000 affected, bodies carried ~240 km. 4. Just Security early-edition brief, 31 Aug 2026 — Kyiv fifth day; Ratcliffe/Moscow trilateral float, single-source, flagged.

SINGAPORE • ONLINE SAFETY

The State Reaches for the Off Switch on Autoplay

Josephine Teo has set out the next step: a real minimum age of 13 on six named platforms, autoplay and infinite scroll off by default for teenagers, and a daily time limit parents can set. Legislation comes in 2027. The hard part is the one word nobody can yet verify – the age.

The Prime Minister said the quiet part at the National Day Rally: today's system, where a child simply declares a birthday, is "just not good enough."¹ On 28 August the Minister for Digital Development and Information, Josephine Teo, put shape to the fix. Six "Designated Social Media Services" — Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, HardwareZone, X and YouTube — would face mandatory age assurance, a minimum age of 13, and a duty to give 13-to-17-year-olds an "age-appropriate experience" or lose the right to serve any under-18 at all.¹

The design targets the mechanics of the feed, not just the front door. Engagement features built to hold a teenager — autoplay, infinite scroll — would be off by default; a daily time limit would apply, adjustable by a parent; contact from strangers would be curbed. The legislation is to be tabled in early 2027, and platforms that refuse the safeguards risk being barred from under-18s entirely.²

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NAMED PLATFORMS — FACEBOOK, INSTAGRAM, TIKTOK, HARDWAREZONE, X, YOUTUBE — FACING MANDATORY AGE CHECKS AND A MINIMUM AGE OF 13¹

The methods on the table are where the privacy fight will land: government ID, credit-card matching, facial-age estimation, or usage-pattern analysis, any of which trades one kind of exposure for another. The Prime Minister's framing at the Rally — self-declaration is "just not good enough" — commits the state to a check, and the argument now shifts from whether to verify age to how, and who holds the data that proves it.¹

The economic desk gets a footnote of its own this week: MAS core inflation rose to 2.0 per cent year-on-year in July, its fastest since October 2024, up

from 1.6 in June, and the central bank nudged its 2026 core forecast up to a 1.5–2.5 per cent band.³ After a year of easing prices, that is a small turn worth marking, and it colours the Macro Desk's read (p14).

ON THE LEDGER

The housing delta. Last week's raised BTO and EC income ceilings (S\$16k / S\$18k, first in seven years) now apply to HFE letters from 24 August, and the next BTO exercise shifts from October to November — the queue widens before a single flat is added.³

The enforcement question. Whether "age-appropriate experience" means a curated feed or merely a switched-off autoplay is undefined until the 2027 bill — and the platforms, not the ministry, will write the first draft of what it looks like in practice.²

THE CHATTER • THE GROUND WAS ALREADY SORE

The policy lands on primed soil. When HardwareZone rolled out Singpass-based age checks in January, its own users revolted over privacy, surveillance and the erosion of the anonymity the forum was built on, some reporting a drop in activity. That HardwareZone is now itself a Designated Service is not lost on the regulars.

The Online Citizen (28 Jan 2026) thread reactions — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • THE NUMBER YOU CANNOT CHECK

Age assurance is only as good as the check behind it, and the checks on offer — government ID, credit-card matching, face-estimation, usage-pattern analysis — each trade privacy for accuracy. Australia's world-first under-16 ban is the warning: eSafety's own August review found roughly eight in ten under-16s still on the platforms three months in, blaming weak assurance (p12). A line on the feed is easy to draw and hard to hold.

eSafety review via Al Jazeera (3 Aug 2026) — characterised

SOURCES 1. AsiaOne, 31 Aug 2026; MDDI newsroom, "Singapore's next steps in building child-safe digital environments" — six Designated Services, minimum age 13, age-appropriate experience for 13–17; PM Wong at NDR ("just not good enough"). 2. The Star / Asia News Network, 31 Aug 2026 — autoplay/infinite-scroll off by default, daily time limit (parent-adjustable), legislation early 2027, bar on serving under-18s for non-compliance. 3. MTI Consumer Price Developments, July 2026 — MAS core inflation 2.0% y/y (from 1.6% June), 2026 core forecast raised to 1.5–2.5%. General reporting.

THE ATELIER • LEATHER BELTS

Everything That Matters Is at the Cut Edge

A belt is the easiest luxury object to judge cold, because the whole truth is visible at the buckle end and the trimmed edge. Learn four things and you will out-read the shop — and find that the last hundred and fifty dollars buys fit, not years.

Four words decide a belt, and the first is the grade. Full-grain is the entire top layer of the hide, surface intact — the strongest fibres, the layer that patinas rather than peels, and effectively the only grade a buy-once reader should touch.¹ Top-grain has that surface sanded off and sprayed — smoother, weaker, and, the tell, what most three-hundred-to-eleven-hundred-dollar designer belts actually are. "Genuine leather" is a marketing floor that cracks in a year or two; "bonded leather" is glued scrap that splits.

The second word is construction: the grail is a single strip cut from one hide, with nothing to delaminate; cheaper belts glue two thin layers, and the glue line is the failure point.¹ The third is tannage — vegetable-tanned leather patinas, and bridle (veg-tan stuffed with waxes, finished both sides) is the heritage choice, with Hermann Oak and Wickett & Craig in the US and Sedgwick and Baker in the UK the tannery names the community reveres.²

14 oz

THE HARNESS-LEATHER WEIGHT A SERIOUS ONE-PIECE BELT RUNS — ROUGHLY 3.5–4.5MM OF SINGLE-CUT HIDE³

The fourth word is the buckle, the biggest hidden tax: solid brass, stainless or nickel-plated brass, never pot-metal. Chicago screws let you swap buckle or strap — the keep-it-forever feature; a fine strap on a cast-alloy buckle is the commonest hidden compromise.²

The makers sort into three tiers. Entry of quality: Orion (~US\$62–67) and Amish one-piece full-grain (US\$34–49). The sweet spot, where durability flattens, is US\$89–150: Hanks (hundred-year warranty, US\$89), Tanner Goods (bridle, Chicago-screw, US\$135), Popov (lifetime, ~US\$129), Maxwell Scott (~US\$149). The grail — US\$150 up — is Equus made-to-measure bridle, Anderson's woven leather, and Japanese houses like Kobashi.³

THE CHATTER • WHAT THE ENDGAME THREADS SAY

Two endgames, by hemisphere: in American buy-it-for-life circles the "buy this and stop" belt is a Hanks; in British tailoring forums it is a made-to-measure English bridle belt in the Equus mould. Permanent Style canonised the second; r/BuyItForLife lives on the first.

Permanent Style; Styleforum; r/BuyItForLife — characterised

THE SINGAPORE REALITY

Who ships, and the tropical catch. Hanks, Orion, Tanner Goods, Popov, Maxwell Scott and the UK Equus makers all ship here; Bynd Artisan is the local workshop. The weather is the warning: at 80–90 per cent humidity, veg-tan and bridle mould fastest. Store below ~55–60 per cent RH with silica gel, never in sealed plastic, and condition every four to six weeks.⁴

THE SCEPTIC • THE LOGO IS THE WHOLE GAME AT THE TOP

The Hermès H buckle runs US\$900–1,100; Ferragamo US\$450–550, and its leather is widely called top-grain, not full-grain. No designer buckle outlasts an eighty-nine-dollar Hanks. The honest line: a sixty-dollar one-piece full-grain belt is about ninety-five per cent of a three-hundred-dollar bespoke one in durability — the last five per cent is fit and craft, not more years.²

Gentleman's Gazette; Extrabux summaries — characterised

NEXT ON THE BENCH — YOU PICK THE CATEGORY

Everyday backpacks — one-bag, commute to carry-on: ballistic nylon versus waxed canvas versus full-grain, and the hardware that outlives the zip.

Cashmere knitwear — grams, ply and fibre length decoded, and where the pilling-versus-price line really sits behind "100% cashmere."

Japanese selvedge denim — loom width, ounce weight, rope-dyed indigo, and the fade-forever case from Momotaro down to the value tier.

SOURCES 1. Leather-grade primers (full-grain vs top-grain vs "genuine"/bonded; one-piece vs glued two-layer) — Gentleman's Gazette, maker guides. 2. Permanent Style; Styleforum "best belts" threads; Gentleman's Gazette / Extrabux (designer brand-tax; Ferragamo top-grain) — community sentiment characterised, forums not deep-read this pass, flagged. 3. Maker listings, current: Orion (US\$62–67), Amish one-piece (US\$34–49), Hanks (US\$89; 100-yr warranty), Tanner Goods (US\$135), Popov (~US\$129), Maxwell Scott (~US\$149), Anderson's (US\$98–225), Kobashi Studio (Tochigi 4.5mm). 4. Local leather-care and humidity guides (switts.com.sg; drycleaning.com.sg); City Nomads (local ateliers) — SG shipping, climate and mould discipline.

TECHNOLOGY · CHIPS

Nvidia Prints Ninety-Six Billion — as Its Biggest Customer Builds a Rival

A record quarter, ninety-two per cent of it data-centre, lands the same week the die detail arrives on the inference chip OpenAI and Broadcom built to bench against it. The margin, and the clearest attempt on it, in one news cycle.

Nvidia posted the number that frames the industry: record quarterly revenue of US\$96.2 billion, up 106 per cent on the year, with the data-centre line alone at US\$89 billion — about ninety-two per cent of the whole company.¹ That figure is the margin the rest of the sector is trying to climb inside, and this week the clearest attempt on it got its details. It came, pointedly, from Nvidia's own biggest customer.

The attempt is "Jalapeño," and the correction to carry from a fortnight ago is that it is not Nvidia's — it is OpenAI's, built with Broadcom, an inference ASIC aimed at the cost of running models rather than training them. At Hot Chips 2026 the engineers filled in the die this desk first flagged in No.87: a reticle-scale chip around 840 square millimetres, 216 gigabytes of HBM4, a rated 700-watt envelope, low-volume production late this year, and vendor benchmarks of 1.5 to 1.9 times the throughput per kilowatt of Nvidia's outgoing GB300.² Custom silicon is the one line item that dents the data-centre story, and the biggest buyer designing its own is the signal.

US\$89bn

NVIDIA'S QUARTERLY DATA-CENTRE REVENUE — ABOUT 92% OF THE COMPANY, AND THE NUMBER CUSTOM CHIPS ARE AIMED AT¹

Two continuity threads advance without a new peg to lead on. The reported US\$12.9 billion Nvidia purchase of Hugging Face remains just that — reported, unsigned, unconfirmed by either party, and conspicuously unaddressed on Nvidia's own earnings call, with regulators expected to eye the model-distribution chokepoint it would create.³ And Zhipu's GLM-5.3, whose weights dropped around 28 August, turns out to carry not a blanket "revenue-gated" licence but a targeted one: model-as-a-service providers above US\$10 billion in revenue need a

security review, which aims the leash at hyperscalers and leaves ordinary users untouched (p8).⁴

Read together, the three stories rhyme: a buyer building its own silicon, a would-be owner buying the commons the open-model world thought it shared, and a licence that gates the biggest players out of a model everyone else can run free. Each is a move to control a chokepoint — the chip, the hub, the weights — and each is being announced faster than the market can price whether it holds. The label ("acquired," "beats Nvidia," "open weights") is out ahead of the thing, again.²

STILL ON THE BENCH

The regulatory read. A Nvidia-Hugging Face deal would stack a distribution chokepoint on top of Nvidia's existing hardware dominance — the kind of vertical reach that draws both US and EU scrutiny. Reported, not signed; the antitrust question is live before the ink is.³

THE CHATTER · HACKER NEWS READS THE SLIDE

The top critique is that it is not apples to apples: Jalapeño is a fixed-function inference part measured in low-precision formats, benched against a general-purpose chip. The mood on r/hardware is that custom silicon is a slow-burn threat to Nvidia's margins, not an overnight one — "a real dent in three years, not this quarter."

Hacker News; r/hardware — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · WHOSE NUMBERS ARE THESE

Every performance figure here is OpenAI-supplied and not independently reproduced; production qualification is unfinished; and Jalapeño has not been benched against Nvidia's next-generation Vera Rubin, only against the outgoing GB300. Treat the win as a vendor slide, not a verdict — the same standard MERIDIAN applies to any launch benchmark.

DataCenterDynamics; CNBC — characterised

SOURCES 1. Nvidia fiscal-Q2 results (~26–27 Aug 2026) — revenue US\$96.2B (+106% YoY), data centre US\$89.0B (+117%), Q3 guide US\$108B. 2. DataCenterDynamics (700W TDP, Hot Chips 2026, ~840mm², 216GB HBM4); CNBC, 26 Aug 2026 — OpenAI+Broadcom "Jalapeño" (first flagged No.87), vendor benchmarks 1.5–1.9× throughput/kW vs GB300, OpenAI-supplied/flagged. 3. The Information; TechCrunch (26 Aug); CNBC (27 Aug) — Nvidia-Hugging Face ~US\$12.9B reported, unsigned/unconfirmed, flagged. 4. Zhipu GLM-5.3 licence terms — bespoke non-MIT, security review for >US\$10B-revenue MaaS providers; weights ~28 Aug.

THE HOME LAB · LOCAL LLMs

A Quant Built for the Exact Chip on Your Desk

NVFP4 — Nvidia's Blackwell-native four-bit float — is the first quantisation aimed at the RTX 5090's own silicon rather than a lowest common denominator. It is early, single-sourced, and pointed in the right direction. Plus the Qwen4 preview from No.85, now running by expert-offload.

The most interesting thing to reach a home rig this week is not a model but a number format. A community build has appeared of GLM-5.3-Flash in NVFP4 — Nvidia's Blackwell-native four-bit float, the format the RTX 5090 accelerates in hardware rather than emulating the way it does the older integer quants everyone has been running.¹ The promise is real quality at four bits with the speed the card was actually built for; the caveat is equally real — it is one uploader's work so far, so the accuracy-recovery claims want independent perplexity sweeps before anything load-bearing rides on them. But the direction is what matters: quantisation aimed at the chip on the desk, not at the lowest common denominator a portable GGUF has to satisfy.

It arrives as the model the sub has chewed on all summer gets its day-one quants. The Qwen4-architecture preview this desk flagged in No.85 — Qwen3.8-Flash-Next, 125 billion parameters that fire only six at a time — now has GGUF builds up via Unsloth and llama.cpp, and the footprints confirm the earlier read: about 112 gigabytes at four bits across VRAM and RAM, so it runs by expert-offload, not on the card alone.² The 5090 holds the active experts; system RAM holds the rest.

6B / 125B

QWEN3.8-FLASH-NEXT'S ACTIVE-VS-TOTAL PARAMETERS — THE RATIO THAT LETS A MID-VRAM CARD HOST A VERY LARGE MODEL VIA EXPERT OFFLOAD²

What actually runs as the daily driver, though, is still the reader's own three-bit GLM-5.3-Flash — natively multimodal, MIT-licensed, and the workhorse both stories orbit. NVFP4 promises to make it faster on the exact card; the Qwen preview shows where the

architecture is heading. Neither displaces the workhorse yet, and that is the honest state of a home lab in 2026: the frontier arrives as a preview and a format before it arrives as a model you keep.¹

ALSO ON THE RIG

The RAM question is back. With expert-offload the daily-driver play for 300-billion-parameter class models, the binding constraint has moved from VRAM to system RAM — and the buy-once upgrade this cycle is not a second GPU but 128 gigabytes of fast DDR5, which turns the 5090 from "won't fit" into "hosts the active experts."¹

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE SUB ACTUALLY WANTS

The daily-driver consensus is still GLM-5.3-Flash — natively multimodal, MIT-licensed, the reader's own three-bit workhorse. The standing gripes are output speed, the roughly 328-gigabyte footprint of the full GLM-5.3, and a suspicion that the headline API price was a temporary discount. The sub also spent a week fingerprinting a stealth model by its tokenizer before Zhipu confirmed it was GLM-family — the kind of forensic fun that is the culture's real pastime.

r/LocalLLaMA round-ups — aggregated, characterised

THE SCEPTIC · ONE UPLOADER, ONE PREVIEW

Both stories carry the same warning in different keys. The NVFP4 build is a single uploader's work, and FP4 quants have shipped before with quiet accuracy loss that only a perplexity sweep catches. Qwen3.8-Flash-Next is a preview of an unreleased architecture whose hybrid-attention quants have historically been brittle. Treat both as weekend experiments until third-party accuracy numbers land, not as the workhorse.

Community engine maintainers — characterised

SOURCES 1. Hugging Face community NVFP4 build of GLM-5.3-Flash (Nvidia Blackwell-native FP4, hardware-accelerated on the RTX 5090) — single uploader, accuracy claims unverified, flagged. 2. Unsloth run guide; local-ai-zone deep-dive — Qwen3.8-Flash-Next (Qwen4-architecture preview, first covered No.85), 125B-A6B, 512 experts/10 active, 262K context; GGUF footprints ~112GB (4-bit VRAM+RAM), runs by expert-offload. General home-lab reporting; not investment or hardware-purchase advice.

THE KIT · WEARABLES

The Ring That Lasts a Fortnight and Asks for Nothing

The Ultrahuman Ring Pro ships with a two-week battery, no subscription and full waterproofing — the buy-once answer to a category built on monthly fees. And the camera-free glasses this desk flagged in No.87 finally go on sale this week.

The wearable question in 2026 is not battery or sensors; it is the monthly bill, and the Ultrahuman Ring Pro answers it by not sending one. About fifteen days of charge (up to forty-five with the dock), waterproof to 100 metres, a new dual-core on-chip sensor — and every feature in the box, no subscription — for around US\$349 on sale.¹ Engadget and Tech Advisor rate its sleep tracking among the best in the category; the honest knocks are a slightly bulkier body and step counts that run low. For a buy-once reader, that is the cleaner story than the rings that lock their best insight behind a recurring fee.

The divide is the whole point. Oura and Whoop, the category's names, put their most useful analysis behind a subscription; Ultrahuman and the Pixel-adjacent rings hand it over with the hardware. The reader who buys a tool to own it should read the fee schedule before the sensor list — it is the specification the launch pages bury, and the one that compounds.¹

~15 days

THE ULTRAHUMAN RING PRO'S BATTERY — NO SUBSCRIPTION, WATERPROOF TO 100M, ~US\$349¹

The glasses, meanwhile, keep their promise on schedule. The camera-free RayNeo iO this desk flagged in No.87 goes on sale on 4 September, live at IFA in Berlin, at US\$479 (US\$529 with the case): a 33-gram frame with a monochrome green heads-up display, no camera and no speakers.² One correction rides along with the launch — the "two days" figure was standby; the 240-milliamp-hour cell does about

six hours of continuous translation. It is a discreet prompter and translator, not a face computer, and that restraint is the appeal: a frame that reads as ordinary glasses, worn all day.

ALSO ON THE SHELF

The category's real fork. Rings split into subscription (Oura, Whoop) and buy-once (Ultrahuman, Samsung, the Pixel-adjacent set); glasses split into camera (Ray-Ban Meta) and camera-free HUD (RayNeo iO). Both forks are really about what you are willing to carry — a fee, or a lens pointed at the room.¹

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE REVIEWERS KEEP SAYING

On the ring, the shipping-and-reviewed one, the consensus is that the no-subscription model plus a genuinely long battery is the thing that wins buy-once buyers, sleep tracking the standout metric. On the glasses, the pre-launch hands-ons (Digital Trends, PhoneArena, The Gadgeteer) keep landing on the sub-35-gram weight as what could make all-day wear real.

Engadget; Tech Advisor; Digital Trends — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · READ THE SMALL PRINT ON BOTH

The ring under-counts steps and is bulkier than a plain band, and "no subscription" can change with a firmware generation — watch the terms, not the launch promise. The glasses are monochrome, text-only and about six hours of real translation, not two days; a green HUD is a long way from the colour overlays the category keeps selling. Neither verdict is final until the units are in independent hands.

Wareable; Notebookcheck; TechPowerUp — characterised

SOURCES 1. TechPowerUp; Notebookcheck — RayNeo iO launch, on sale 4 Sep 2026, US\$479 (US\$529 w/ case), 33g, monochrome green waveguide, no camera/speakers, 55-language translation, 240mAh (~2 days typical / ~6h continuous translation). Pre-launch hands-ons only; no independent lab review yet, flagged. 2. Engadget; Tech Advisor — Ultrahuman Ring Pro, ~15-day battery (to 45 w/ charger), no subscription, 100m waterproof, ~US\$349 on sale; praised sleep tracking, knocked for bulk and step under-count.

THE GOOD LIFE · AUDIO

Two Kinds of Driver in One Ear Cup

Noble Audio's first wireless flagship runs a dynamic and a planar-magnetic driver together — the sort of thing that used to mean a cable and a headphone amp. It is the news hook in an autumn the hi-fi desk got loud, and a reminder that "endgame" is a word to measure, not to trust.

The FoKus Artemis is the maker of the Iris IEM going wireless at the top of the range, and its trick is one that belonged to the wired world: a hybrid drive train pairing a dynamic driver with a planar-magnetic one in the same cup, over Bluetooth.¹ The pitch is the best of both — the slam of a dynamic, the speed and low distortion of a planar — without a cable or an amplifier. It is the freshest single object in a busy month, and it earns the lead precisely because it is a genuinely new configuration rather than another revision.

Around it, the autumn drops stack up for the audio-minded reader. KEF's sculptural LS Luxe active speakers — the Ross Lovegrove design this desk first met back in No.62 — are shipping into the same window, and the wider round-ups gather a season's worth of flagship wireless.² The through-line to the rest of the book is not subtle: this is the issue whose three-page feature goes down the vinyl rabbit hole (p15), and the reader assembling a real system will find the two desks talking to each other.

The buy-once logic cuts differently across the category, and it is worth stating for a reader weighing where the money should go. A passive speaker or a wired IEM is a genuine keep-forever object — the drivers outlast the fashion, and there is no battery to die. An active wireless speaker or a flagship wireless headphone is not: the cell degrades, the Bluetooth codec dates, and the resale curve is steep. The FoKus Artemis is the more exciting object; the LS Luxe, or a wired chain feeding the turntable on page fifteen, is the more durable one.²

ALSO WORTH A LISTEN

The season's round-up. Beyond the Artemis, the August audio slate that reviewers flagged runs to new flagship wireless cans and a clutch of active desktop speakers — a busy autumn for the desk, and a reminder that the wired-versus-wireless durability question applies to every one of them.²

"Endgame" is a claim a headphone makes about itself. A measurement is what tells you whether it's true.

2

DRIVER TYPES — DYNAMIC + PLANAR-MAGNETIC — IN ONE WIRELESS EAR CUP, THE FOKUS ARTEMIS'S WHOLE THESIS¹

And a line for the shelf: the Omega Speedmaster 38 this desk led on in No.86 — the Moonwatch-styled automatic, entry around US\$6,500 — is still awaiting the deliveries, owner reviews and a Singapore price that would give it a fresh peg. Handsome, and covered; when the wrists and the local sticker arrive, so does the follow-up.³

THE CHATTER · HEAD-FI WANTS NUMBERS FIRST

The hybrid-driver claim is exactly the kind that the measurement-literate crowd on Head-Fi and r/audiophile treats as a hypothesis, not a headline. Their line on any "endgame" flagship is consistent: a frequency-response plot and a distortion measurement, then we talk. Warmth toward the ambition, patience on the verdict.

Head-Fi; r/audiophile — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · FLAGSHIP WIRELESS DEPRECIATES FAST

Two cautions. First, a hybrid-driver wireless set lives or dies on the crossover and the tuning, neither of which a spec sheet shows — the FoKus Artemis needs an independent measurement before the "endgame" talk means anything. Second, flagship wireless cans lose value faster than almost any audio object; the buy-once case here is weaker than it is for a wired IEM or a passive speaker.

Gear Patrol; The Gadgeteer round-ups — characterised

SOURCES 1. Gear Patrol; The Gadgeteer (Aug 2026 audio round-ups) — Noble Audio FoKus Artemis, first wireless set combining dynamic + planar-magnetic drivers; single/aggregated sourcing, price and measurements to be confirmed, flagged. 2. Gear Patrol; What Hi-Fi — KEF LS Luxe active wireless speakers (Ross Lovegrove; first covered No.62), autumn hi-fi releases. 3. Continuity: Omega Speedmaster 38 (2026), Good Life lead No.86 — awaiting deliveries/owner reviews/SG price; not re-covered. General reporting; not purchase advice.

SCREEN & SOUND · VENICE

The Lido Raises Its Curtain on Murdoch

The 83rd Venice Film Festival opens with Danny Boyle's Ink — Guy Pearce as Rupert Murdoch. The lineup reads thin on paper and thinner on women; the verdict waits on the McDonagh and Lee Chang-dong premieres, not opening night.

There is a held breath before a festival, and Venice lets it out on 2 September with Danny Boyle's *Ink* — Guy Pearce as Rupert Murdoch, adapted from James Graham's stage play about the 1969 birth of the Sun.¹ No competition reviews exist yet; nothing has screened. What the trade press has instead is a talking point — only one woman among the twenty competition directors, a parity backslide it has flagged loudly — and a complaint that the field is thin on Hollywood wattage.

The honest counter is that "underwhelming on paper" is a pre-festival cliché the Lido has embarrassed before; it has launched three of the last several Best Picture winners. Judge it on the heavy end instead: Martin McDonagh's *Wild Horse Nine*, Lee Chang-dong's *Possible Love* (Netflix-blocked from Cannes, so Venice is its bow), Hirokazu Kore-eda's *Look Back*, and Werner Herzog's *Bucking Fastard*.¹ The reviews come after those premieres, not before.

1 of 20

WOMEN DIRECTORS IN THE VENICE COMPETITION — THE PARITY BACKSLIDE THE TRADE PRESS IS FLAGGING¹

The box office closed a loop this desk has tracked. *Coyote vs. Acme* — the film Warner shelved as a tax write-off — settled its opening at about US\$15.5 million domestic, second behind a fifth-weekend *Spider-Man*, on notices around 95 per cent and an A CinemaScore.² The number the desk was waiting on (No.87 had only a projection) landed on the right side of the rescue; the legs, not the opening, still decide whether it pays.

And for the collector's shelf rather than the box office: 18 September is the date to circle, but circle it warily. Beck's fifteenth, *Ride Lonesome*, lands the same Friday as Orville Peck's *Mule*, Ezra Collective's

Here Because of Hope and *Empress Of's Dream House* — a four-album pile-up, with Ellie Goulding and Amyl and the Sniffers also in the September window.³ Good for the crate; brutal for the charts.

4

NOTABLE ALBUMS STACKED ON 18 SEP — BECK, ORVILLE PECK, EZRA COLLECTIVE, EMPRESS OF — A CHART-DILUTING FRIDAY³

ALSO WORTH THE TICKET

The wider release slate. Beyond the 18 Sep pile-up, the September window carries Ellie Goulding and Amyl and the Sniffers, and the Afrobeats star Ayra Starr's recent *Starr Girl* is still working the charts — a month deep enough that even strong records will fight for a first-week number.³

On the festival wires. Watch the Lido for the McDonagh and Lee Chang-dong reactions in the first week; Venice has a habit of turning a "thin on paper" field into an awards-season launchpad by its second weekend.¹

THE CHATTER · A VILLAIN GETS ITS COMEUPPANCE

On *r/boxoffice* and *r/movies* the framing writes the goodwill: the film a studio buried outperforming and out-reviewing expectations is the rare story where the audience roots for the movie against its own owner. The "\$15.5 million is only okay for the budget" caveat is present, and drowned out.

r/boxoffice; *r/movies* — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · FIVE ALBUMS, ONE FRIDAY

For the collector's ear, 18 September is the date — Beck's *Ride Lonesome*, his fifteenth — but it is also a pile-up: Orville Peck, Ezra Collective and *Empress Of* all land the same day. A five-album Friday means chart dilution and soft first-week numbers even for strong records. Good for the shelf; hard on the standings.

Consequence; DIY release calendars — characterised

SOURCES 1. Screen Daily (Venice 2026 lineup); Deadline (talking points; one woman in 20-film competition) — 83rd Venice Film Festival opens 2 Sep with Danny Boyle's *Ink*; McDonagh/Lee/Kore-eda/Herzog in competition. 2. Cartoon Brew (opening ~US\$15.5M domestic, second behind *Spider-Man*); RT/CinemaScore (~95% Certified Fresh, A) — *Coyote vs. Acme*, opened 28 Aug 2026 (tracked from No.87's projection). 3. Consequence 2026 release tracker; DIY September calendar — Beck *"Ride Lonesome"* and others, 18 Sep 2026.

THE FAMILY DESK • SCREENS & THE LAW

The Phone Leaves the Classroom. Now the Law Comes for the Feed.

For a twelve-year-old in Secondary 1, the rules are arriving from two directions at once — a school-day device ban already in force, and an age law taking shape for the feed at home. The evidence says the evening, not the classroom, is where a parent's work now lives.

The reader's daughter, born in July 2014, is twelve and settling into Secondary 1, and the policy weather around her changed this year. Since January, MOE has banned smartphones and smartwatches for the whole secondary-school day — recess, CCAs and remedials included, devices stored away, not merely silenced.¹ Layered on top now is the age-13 assurance and the autoplay-off, daily-limit proposals the Singapore desk sets out this issue (p5). Between them, the school owns the daytime; the evening is the parent's lane.

What the evidence actually supports is narrower than the headlines and more useful. A 2026 meta-analysis pooling many longitudinal studies found the association between social media and poorer outcomes strongest in early adolescence — precisely the 11-to-13 band she is in — and a separate body of work finds the effect larger in girls than boys.² Pew's 2025 survey put concrete numbers on it: 25 per cent of teen girls say social media has hurt their mental health, against 14 per cent of boys, with girls also reporting worse effects on sleep and confidence.³

25%

OF TEEN GIRLS SAY SOCIAL MEDIA HAS HURT THEIR MENTAL HEALTH — AGAINST 14% OF BOYS (PEW, 2025)³

The number to keep on the desk, though, is the one from Australia. Its world-first under-16 ban removed millions of accounts at launch — and eSafety's own August review found more than eight in ten under-16s still using the platforms three months later, blaming weak age assurance.⁴ A ban is a line drawn; enforcement is whether it holds, and so far it mostly has not.

The lesson for a Singapore parent is not fatalism but focus. If a national ban with the force of law leaks four children in five, a household rule will leak too —

which means the goal is not a wall but a set of habits that survive the leak: the phone that sleeps outside the bedroom, the app the parent has actually opened and understands, the conversation that makes the child want to tell you when something online goes wrong. The law and the school ban buy time and cover; they do not raise the child.⁴

Sec 1

THE READER'S DAUGHTER'S YEAR — THE EXACT 11-TO-13 BAND WHERE THE SOCIAL-MEDIA ASSOCIATION RUNS STRONGEST²

THE CHATTER • WHERE PARENTS ACTUALLY LAND

The pragmatic consensus among parents and clinicians converges on function over minutes: the phone out of the bedroom overnight (sleep is where the girl-specific harms concentrate), the coming daily limit co-set with the child rather than imposed, and attention paid to whether use is displacing sleep, school and friendships — not to the raw hour count. The school's ban does the daytime for you.

Parenting and clinical guidance — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • THE PANIC MAY HAVE IT BACKWARDS

Candice Odgers of UC Irvine and Andrew Przybylski of Oxford argue the causal evidence is thinner and more mixed than the headlines suggest — Odgers notes she repeatedly tried and failed to show social media harms mental health, points to the large ABCD study finding no dramatic tech-linked changes, and warns a ban-first approach "gets the problem wrong," diverting help from the minority of children already struggling. Not a licence to ignore it; a caution against treating a hard question as settled.⁵

Odgers (UC Irvine); Przybylski (Oxford) — characterised

General guidance for parents, not medical advice; age-band findings are population-level and do not describe any individual child.

SOURCES 1. Mothership, 30 Nov 2025 — MOE all-day smartphone/smartwatch ban in secondary schools, from Jan 2026. 2. 2026 meta-analysis of longitudinal studies (association strongest in early adolescence; larger in girls) — carried via research aggregator; primary-paper figure treated as indicative, flagged. 3. Pew Research Center, 22 Apr 2025 — 25% of teen girls vs 14% of boys report social media hurt their mental health; sleep/confidence effects. 4. Al Jazeera, 3 Aug 2026 — Australian eSafety August review: >80% of under-16s still on platforms three months after the ban. 5. UC Irvine / Depression Institute; Techdirt (21 Jan 2026) — Odgers & Przybylski on the mixed causal evidence and the ABCD study.

THE FAMILY DESK • THE EVENING PLAYBOOK

The Three Moves That Do the Real Work

If the daytime is handled and the law is still a year off, the highest-yield changes at home are small, specific, and about sleep and displacement — not about counting hours.

The gap between what the research supports and what a parent can actually do is narrower than the debate suggests, and it comes down to three moves. First, the phone leaves the bedroom overnight — a single rule that protects the one outcome (sleep) where the girl-specific evidence is strongest and least contested.¹ Second, the daily limit that Singapore's law will soon default on is co-set now, with the child in the room, so the number is a shared agreement rather than a confiscation to be routed around. Third, the thing to watch is displacement — is the feed eating sleep, homework, or seeing friends in person — rather than the raw minute count a dashboard shows.

The reason to resist the minute-count reflex is in the sceptics' own data: the ABCD study and the mixed longitudinal record suggest that for most children the harm, where it exists, tracks how the time is spent and what it replaces, not how much of it there is.² A child using a screen to talk to real friends after a full, slept, schooled day is not the child the worst findings describe. The band matters, too — guidance built for a ten-year-old is not guidance for a twelve-year-old entering secondary school, and the research the desk cites is stratified by exactly that age.

13

THE MINIMUM AGE SINGAPORE PROPOSES TO ENFORCE — ONE YEAR OLDER THAN THE READER'S DAUGHTER IS NOW³

Which leaves a practical footnote for this particular household: at twelve, she sits just under the line the new law would draw. The account she may already hold, and the habits around it, are the ones the assurance regime will eventually test — which makes the next year the window to set the evening rules by agreement, before they arrive by statute.³

WHAT "GOOD" LOOKS LIKE — GENERAL GUIDANCE

Sleep first. The best-evidenced single intervention for this age band is a consistent bedtime with the phone charging outside the bedroom; sleep loss is the mechanism most

reliably linked to the mood and attention effects the studies find.¹

Watch the swap, not the clock. The useful question is what a screen hour is replacing — sleep, homework, exercise, seeing friends in person. An hour that displaces none of those is not the hour the worst findings describe.²

Co-author the rules. A limit the child helped set is a limit she is less likely to route around; the coming statutory default works best as a floor the family has already agreed to, not a confiscation.³

The band matters more than the number, and it is worth saying plainly for a household with a twelve-year-old: the research the desk cites is stratified by age, and guidance built for a ten-year-old is not guidance for a girl entering secondary school. The 11-to-13 window is where the association the studies find is strongest, and it is also the window where independence is meant to grow — which is the genuine tension a parent is managing, not a number a dashboard can settle.²

THE CHATTER • THE SECONDARY-ONE REALITY

Parents of new Secondary 1 students report the same pattern the school ban intends: the phone is genuinely away during the day, and the friction has migrated home to the evening and the weekend. The group-chat, not the classroom, is where the negotiation now happens — which is exactly where the evidence says the attention belongs.

Local parenting forums — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • DON'T OUTSOURCE JUDGEMENT TO A NUMBER

A daily-limit slider and an age gate are policy instruments, not parenting. The risk in both — the school ban included — is that a family reads the rule as the whole job and stops watching the child. The evidence's own message is the opposite: the tool buys time and attention; it does not spend it for you.

Ogders; child-development researchers — characterised

General guidance for parents, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1. Sleep-and-adolescence guidance (phone out of the bedroom; sleep the best-evidenced outcome) — clinical summaries. 2. ABCD study and mixed longitudinal record on how screen time is spent vs how much — via Ogders/Przybylski commentary (see p12). 3. MDDI / AsiaOne, Aug 2026 — proposed minimum age 13, age-appropriate experience for 13–17 (see p5). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE MACRO DESK • THE REGIME

A New Chair Says It Isn't Beaten — and the Anti-Fiat Trade Takes the Hit

Kevin Warsh used Jackson Hole to warn that inflation isn't done. The market flipped from pricing a September cut to weighing a hike — and then Hormuz put oil past ninety. Gold and bitcoin fell together; the dollar firmed. The whole week is in that one broken pairing.

Name the regime and the rest follows: this is hawkish repricing meeting an oil shock. The pivot is Kevin Warsh, in the Fed chair since May, who used his Jackson Hole address on 29 August to say plainly that inflation "is not beaten yet."¹ A month ago the market priced the 15–16 September meeting as a near-certain cut; it now reads it as a coin-toss between a hold and a hike. Onto that anxiety the Larak strikes (p3) dropped a supply-side jolt, pushing Brent past US\$90.

VWRA	US 10Y	DXY	GOLD	BITCOIN
~195.5	~4.72%	~99.7	~4,447	~78.4k
▲	▲	▲	▼	▼

The result was a clean risk-off in the long-duration and anti-fiat trade. Gold fell about one per cent on the day, now some eight per cent off its late-January record; bitcoin slid roughly three per cent from an \$81,455 high struck the week Warsh's tone first landed, back toward US\$78,400.² The dollar index firmed near 99.7 off its Jackson Hole low, the ten-year held around 4.72 per cent, and the global-aggregate bond proxy stayed pinned near cycle lows as yields refused to fall. Equities were the outlier: VWRA held near its record, around US\$195.5, and Singapore's STI actually rose, up about one per cent to 5,755.³

~\$90.9

BRENT CRUDE, UP BETTER THAN 3% ON THE HORMUZ STRIKES — THE SUPPLY-SIDE JOLT INTO AN INFLATION SCARE²

What it means for the four instruments, as explanation and not advice: a firmer dollar and sticky real yields are the visible headwind on gold and bitcoin, which is why both are the week's casualties despite the geopolitics that usually bids gold. Global bonds stay stuck. VWRA has held up — but its

vulnerability is precisely the loop now forming, where a strait keeps oil high, forces a September hike, and tests the one thing still standing near its highs. The US jobs report is due around 5 September; there is no fresh print this week, so the read is a regime call, not a data verdict.³

THE CHATTER • THE BROKEN PAIRING EVERYONE NOTICED

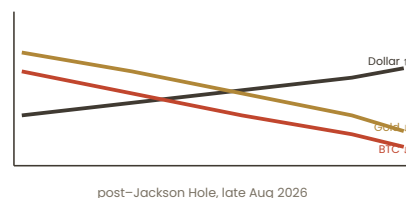
The week's talking point on the market desks is the correlation, not any single level: gold and bitcoin — the two "debasement" trades — falling in lockstep with a rising dollar is the signature of a rates story overpowering a fear story. When the anti-fiat assets sell off into geopolitical risk, the market is telling you higher-for-longer, not risk-off, is driving.

Market strategists; CNBC — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • A COIN-TOSS IS NOT A FORECAST

Every rate-path number here is a market-implied probability, not a promise, and they disagree across trackers — some read a hold as likelier, some a hike. Bitcoin's move is flagged as analysis of the move, not a caution about anyone's portfolio; its volatility is simply higher. And no unverifiable level is invented here — where a print is awaited (jobs, the FOMC), it is held, not guessed.

Rate-futures trackers — characterised



The broken pairing: a firmer dollar with gold and bitcoin falling together — a rates story overpowering a fear story. *Meridian original.*

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

DOLLAR BID

OIL SHOCK

SOURCES 1. Fed Chair Kevin Warsh, Jackson Hole, 29 Aug 2026 ("not beaten yet"); rate-futures repricing for the 15–16 Sept FOMC. 2. Yahoo Finance; CNBC; Bloomberg — gold ~US\$4,447 (~1% day, ~8% off Jan record); bitcoin ~US\$78.4k (off \$81,455 high); Brent ~US\$90.91 (+3.2%). 3. stockanalysis.com (VWRA ~US\$195.5); growbeansprout.com (STI 5,755.36, +0.97%); TradingEconomics (US 10Y ~4.72%, DXY ~99.7). US Aug payrolls due ~5 Sep — not out. Market explanation, not investment advice; forecasts flagged as forecasts.

THE RABBIT HOLE · VINYL RECORDS & TURNTABLES

The Needle, the Ritual, and an Eighteen-Year Climb

A format the industry buried came back and kept coming — eighteen straight years of growth, and forty-four million LPs against thirty-three million CDs. The hook is rarely fidelity. It is the sleeve in your hands, the one album you chose, and a chain where every link is a knob you can turn.

Here is the gateway, and it is almost never what a sceptic expects. It is the first record that beats the stream — usually a well-cut pressing on a friend's proper system, where you hear space and texture a compressed file had flattened; or the inherited crate that needs a deck to play; or simply the ritual, the deliberate, single-album, sleeve-in-hand attention that infinite shuffle killed.¹ The community's own honest read, from r/vinyl to the Steve Hoffman forums, is that the hook is rarely pure sound quality. It is tactility, ownership, artwork, and forced attention — and for this reader it usually arrives through the hi-fi door, the turntable treated as the next component after good speakers.

The scale is real, and it is the part that surprises people. American vinyl revenue grew 7 per cent to US\$1.4 billion in 2024 — an eighteenth consecutive year of growth, the highest since 1984 — and vinyl outsold CDs on units for a third straight year, roughly 44 million LPs against 33 million CDs.² The streak continued into 2025, a nineteenth year, with US vinyl again above the billion mark. One methodological caveat earns its place: Luminate changed how it counts independent-store sales in 2024, so year-on-year unit trends are genuinely contested — some analysts read a soft dip where the headline reads growth.²

Every link in the chain — deck, cartridge, phono stage, the very mat under the record — is a variable you can tune. That is the on-ramp to obsession.

18 yrs

CONSECUTIVE US VINYL REVENUE GROWTH THROUGH 2024
— US\$1.4BN, 44M LPS AGAINST 33M CDS²

SOURCES 1. Community entry narratives — r/vinyl; Steve Hoffman Music Forums (gateway stories, "hook is tactility not fidelity"). 2. RIAA 2024 Year-End Report (US vinyl +7% to US\$1.4bn, 18th year, ~44m LPs vs ~33m CDs); Billboard; RouteNote (2025 continuation); Digital Music News / Consequence (Luminate methodology caveat, flagged). 3. Variety; TechRadar — Record Store Day 2026 (18 Apr, 19th year, 350+ exclusives); Gen Z adoption trend.

And it is broadening, not just greying. The 2024-25 story is Gen Z — teenagers buying vinyl often before they own a turntable, as collectible and merch — arriving alongside the returning Gen X core. Record Store Day, now in its nineteenth year, ran its 2026 edition on 18 April with more than 350 exclusive releases, from Pink Floyd to a functioning three-inch Rolling Stones turntable.³ What the next two pages descend into: the community battlegrounds, the gear ladder from the honest on-ramp to the five-figure grail, the 2025-26 cutting edge, the vocabulary and the scandal that broke the word "analog," a real ninety-day starter path for Singapore, and the sceptic's case.

THE CHATTER · THE FIGHT YOU'LL OVERHEAR FIRST

Walk into r/vinyl or r/audiophile and the standing argument is whether vinyl "sounds better" or merely sounds different — and the most respected voices increasingly hold the middle: when a record beats its digital twin, it is usually a better master, not the format doing magic. Keep that line; it will save you money on page three.

r/vinyl; r/audiophile; Steve Hoffman Forums — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · A RITUAL IS NOT A MEASUREMENT

The measurement-literate case, stated up front so the rest reads honestly: a CD offers about 96 decibels of dynamic range against vinyl's usable 60 to 70, bounded by surface noise and groove geometry. Most new records are cut from a digital master, so there is no analog-source advantage to buy. What you are buying is a ritual and, sometimes, a less-compressed master — both real, neither magic.

SoundGuys; Hydrogenaudio — characterised

THE RABBIT HOLE • THE GEAR

The Ladder, from the Honest On-Ramp to the Grail

Skip the suitcase player — the community's one true bête noire. The real entry is around five hundred dollars; the sweet spot for this reader is a belt-drive deck and a moving-coil cartridge; and the top of the ladder runs to a seventy-thousand-dollar turntable that is furniture as much as machine.

One line on the disposable tier, as the community insists: the all-in-one Crosley and Victrola suitcase players are the thing that ruins records, and the guidance is simply don't — the reasons are in the mistakes below. The real on-ramp starts higher. The Audio-Technica AT-LP120XUSB (~US\$399) is the do-everything direct-drive starter; the Fluance RT85 (~US\$550) ships with an Ortofon 2M Blue and an acrylic platter, an unusually generous spec; and the reviewer's darling is the Rega Planar 1 (~US\$595), a fit-and-forget belt-drive.¹

The sweet spot for this reader is the mid-and-high tier, where the money starts buying real engineering. The Rega Planar 3, cartridge fitted, runs about US\$1,150; up the ladder sit the Planar 6, 8 and 10 and the modern direct-drive icon, the Technics SL-1200GR2 (~US\$2,500).¹ Cartridges are their own ladder: the moving-magnet Ortofon 2M line climbs Red-Blue-Bronze-Black (US\$170 to US\$750), and the step into moving-coil runs Hana SL and ML into the four-figure Umami series. A phono stage completes the chain — the Schiit Mani 2 (US\$149) is the budget benchmark, with Sutherland and Musical Fidelity above.²

US\$71,900

THE SME MODEL 60 — THE GRAIL DECK THE TOP OF THE LADDER ACTUALLY REACHES; FURNITURE AS MUCH AS MACHINE³

The over-the-top tier is where it stops being about fidelity and starts being about objects: the SME Model 60 at about US\$71,900, Clearaudio's 2025–26 range from US\$6,500 to US\$17,900, and the TechDAS, Brinkmann and Dr. Feickert names in five-figure territory.³ The rabbit-hole accessories are their own economy — the endless "which mat" debate, setup

protractors and stylus-force gauges, and record-cleaning machines that climb from vacuum types to the ultrasonic Degritter Mark II at about US\$3,600.

THE CUTTING EDGE — 2025–26, NAMED AND DATED

Rega Planar 6 RS Edition — unveiled at Audio Advice Live in early 2026, £2,000, borrowing upper-range plinth tech, shipping around April–May; the Planar 3 RS preceded it.³

Pro-Ject Debut Reference 10 — announced February 2026 with a new 10-inch one-piece carbon-aluminium tonearm (carbon outside for rigidity, aluminium inside for damping); the most ambitious Debut yet, about S\$2,199 here.³

The ultrasonic wave. The Degritter Mark II is leading a real shift from vacuum to ultrasonic cleaning as the enthusiast default — and this is the rare accessory reviewers say earns its keep, audibly lowering surface noise on used records, with honest diminishing returns on already-clean new vinyl.³

THE CHATTER • WHERE THEY ACTUALLY BUY

Discogs — 18 million releases, its sales history the de-facto pricing bible — runs the second-hand market and the "which pressing" obsession alike; new gear moves through the review-site orbit (AnalogPlanet, What Hi-Fi) and specialist dealers. The buying rule is consistent: upgrade the cartridge before the deck.

Discogs; AnalogPlanet; r/turntables — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • THE LADDER IS A TREADMILL

Each cartridge rung costs two to five times the last, the ultrasonic cleaner is US\$3,600, and "hot stamper" copies sell at multiples of retail for a single lucky pressing. The community itself concedes much of the appeal is ritual and ownership, not fidelity — a point made even on the audiophile-leaning Steve Hoffman forums. The endgame you regret is the one bought to chase a number that a better master would have given you for free.

Steve Hoffman Forums; r/audiophile — characterised

SOURCES 1. Sweetwater; Fluance; AnalogPlanet; Music Direct — AT-LP120XUSB (~US\$399), Fluance RT85 (~US\$550), Rega Planar 1 (~US\$595) / Planar 3 (~US\$1,150 fitted), Technics SL-1200GR2 (~US\$2,500). 2. Turntable Lab; Upscale Audio; Schiit — Ortofon 2M Red-Black (US\$170–750), Hana SL/ML/Umami, Schiit Mani 2 (US\$149). 3. ecoustics; What Hi-Fi; AnalogPlanet; Music Direct — SME Model 60 (~US\$71,900), Clearaudio 2025–26 range, Degritter Mark II (~US\$3,600), Rega Planar 6 RS (£2,000), Pro-Ject Debut Reference 10 (~\$2,199). Prices current Aug–Sep 2026; SGD figures dealer-listed/estimated, flagged.

THE RABBIT HOLE • THE CULTURE & THE FIRST 90 DAYS

The Word That Broke When a Label Told the Truth

Learn the vocabulary, avoid the four beginner sins, and know the scandal that reframed the whole hobby — then a real starter path at Singapore prices, and three candidates for where we go next.

The vocabulary is the map. AAA is all-analog — tape to lacquer to playback, the purist's gold standard; DMM is direct metal mastering; a pressing is a specific manufacturing run, chased by matrix codes etched in the dead wax; VTA, anti-skate and VTF (tracking force, in grams) are the setup knobs; Goldmine grading runs Mint, Near Mint, VG+ down, and NM and VG+ are the trading currency on Discogs.¹ The audiophile-reissue houses — Mobile Fidelity, Analogue Productions, Music Matters — are the premium names.

Which is where the scandal comes in, because it broke the most important word in the hobby. In 2022 Mobile Fidelity admitted that its "Original Master Recording" one-step LPs — sold on an all-analog promise — had used a DSD digital step in the chain since 2011; a class action followed, and MoFi settled for about US\$25 million.² It permanently reframed the AAA debate: if even a premium "all-analog" label was cutting from digital, the promise is frequently unverifiable — the label and the thing, once again, not the same object.

~US\$25m

MOBILE FIDELITY'S SETTLEMENT AFTER ADMITTING ITS "ALL-ANALOG" ONE-STEPS USED A DIGITAL STEP SINCE 2011²

The four beginner sins, by damage: a dirty or worn stylus; wrong tracking force and anti-skate, which permanently carve the groove; no cleaning regimen; and the headline sin, the suitcase player, which tracks at a punishing 7-to-12 grams against a safe 1.5-to-2 — "more damage in one play than three thousand on a good setup."¹ The economics, tiered: casual is S\$400–900 all-in; serious S\$2,000–6,000; obsessive runs S\$15,000 up, into grail decks and hot-stamper originals.

The first ninety days, for Singapore, is lurk-then-spend: read the r/vinyl setup guides, learn grading on Discogs, and go hear systems at The Analog Vault

and Hear Records before buying.³ A realistic entry that will not damage records and can grow — a Project Debut EVO 2 or Rega Planar 1 (~S\$800–1,250 at Retrophonic or AV One), the cartridge it ships with, a Schiit Mani 2 if your amp lacks a phono stage, and a brush-and-fluid kit plus a S\$25 force gauge — runs S\$1,000–1,600 all in.

THE CHATTER • THE SINGAPORE CRATE

The local scene is deeper than the island's size suggests: Roxy Records has traded since 1962, and The Analog Vault, Hear Records and Curated Records anchor the crate-digging. The consensus starter advice is unanimous — buy the deck new from a dealer who will set it up, buy the records second-hand.

TheSmartLocal; Bandwagon; local shop listings — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • WHAT THE HOBBY ADMITS WHEN PRESSED

The honest insiders will tell you the loudness war invaded vinyl too — many new pressings share the compressed CD master — and that surface noise is intrinsic, reduced by a clean setup but never gone. The pleasure is real; the fidelity claim is conditional. Buy the ritual with open eyes, and you will never resent the treadmill you chose not to step on.

Headphonesty; Steve Hoffman Forums — characterised

NEXT DESCENTS — YOU PICK TOMORROW'S HOBBY

Vintage watch collecting — the affordable end: reference-hunting, the honest-dial obsession, and where the fakes hide, without the five-figure grails.

Astrophotography — the smart-telescope wave (Seestar and rivals) versus the traditional mount-and-guiding path, and dark-sky reality from Singapore.

Birding — the eBird-and-optics rabbit hole, the Singapore Birds Project, and the binocular ladder that is its own buy-once question.

SOURCES 1. Community glossaries and setup guides — r/vinyl; VinylEngine; SlashGear (suitcase-player tracking force 7–12g vs 1.5–2g); Goldmine grading. 2. Rolling Stone; MusicTech — Mobile Fidelity 2022 "one-step"/DSD admission and ~US\$25m settlement. 3. TheSmartLocal; Bandwagon; AV One; Retrophonic — Singapore stores (The Analog Vault, Hear Records, Roxy since 1962, Choice Cuts) and starter pricing; SGD figures dealer-listed/estimated, flagged.

FITNESS • THE BASE

The Weighted Walk the Longevity Crowd Calls the Foundation

Rucking — walking under a loaded pack — is 2026's fitness trend because it holds the heart in the aerobic zone while loading bone and posture a plain walk can't. The number underneath it is VO2 max. And a former pro's rebuttal: they just rediscovered Tuesday.

The idea is old enough to be new again. Rucking — walking with a weighted pack — has become the longevity discourse's efficient base because of a simple mechanism: the added load keeps the heart in the aerobic Zone 2 band while adding a bone- and posture-loading stimulus an unweighted walk lacks, and on rolling terrain it spares the knees against running.¹ Reported energy cost runs roughly two to three times ordinary walking at the same pace — though several of the sharper calorie and VO2 claims trace to small or self-reported studies, and are directionally sound rather than gold-standard.

The hard number to anchor on is VO2 max, and the 2026 evidence keeps reinforcing it. A global multi-marathoner cohort of 340 runners, mean age 52, published in Scientific Reports, again found cardiorespiratory fitness among the strongest physical predictors of longevity — high fitness associated with roughly 80 per cent lower long-term mortality than low, and each one-point gain in VO2 max (one millilitre per kilogram per minute) with about 10 per cent lower risk.² A separate 2026 dose analysis found the lowest mortality in people combining aerobic volume with 60 to 119 minutes a week of strength work — the message is to combine modalities, not chase one.

~10%

LOWER MORTALITY RISK PER ONE-POINT GAIN IN VO2 MAX
— THE NUMBER UNDER THE RUCKING TREND²

The practical read for a mid-forties reader with a trainer and a wearable: rucking is a low-cost way to add aerobic base and loaded carry without a new machine — start light, progress the pack slowly to

protect the lower back, and treat it as the Zone 2 floor under the strength and intervals, not a replacement for them. General guidance, not medical advice; clear new loaded-carry volume with a professional.³

THE PROTOCOL, IN BRIEF

The combine-don't-chase rule. The 2026 dose analysis is the number to hold: the lowest mortality sat with people doing aerobic volume *and* 60 to 119 minutes a week of strength — not the aerobic-only or strength-only camps. A ruck is the aerobic base; it does not replace the two strength sessions the data rewards.²

THE CHATTER • THE LONGEVITY FEED

Peter Attia programs a personal weighted, hilly, knee-sparing rucking protocol and pairs it with a VO2 max target he frames as "elite for two decades younger"; Andrew Huberman's feed pushed rucking-and-VO2-max clips into the mainstream this year, and r/longevity and the practitioner Substacks are calling rucking the fitness trend of 2026.

Peter Attia MD; Huberman Lab; r/longevity — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • THEY REDISCOVERED TUESDAY

A widely-shared rebuttal from a former pro cyclist-coach argues Attia frames Zone 2 as a novel discovery when endurance coaches have programmed it for forty years, and critics flag the sheer time cost of the full protocol — five to six hours of Zone 2, three to four of strength, plus mobility — as unrealistic for most working adults. The base is sound; the branding is doing a lot of work.

Roadman Cycling reaction — characterised

General guidance, not medical advice; progress loaded-carry volume gradually and clear it with a professional.

SOURCES 1. Rucking mechanics and energy-cost coverage (Daily Burn, 2026) — ~2–3× walking energy cost; several VO2/calorie claims small/self-reported, flagged. 2. Nature Scientific Reports (2026), multi-marathoner cohort (n=340, mean age 52) — VO2 max among strongest longevity predictors, ~80% lower mortality high-vs-low fitness, ~10% per +1 mL/kg/min; 2026 dose analysis (aerobic + 60–119 min/wk strength). 3. Practitioner guidance — Attia/Huberman; not medical advice.

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

An October That Opens with a Sprint

The season's marquee is a Grand Prix that adds a Sprint for the first time; around it, a Zimmer night, a stacked concert calendar, and a sumo basho to plan the flights around.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 20 SEP** **Belle & Sebastian** — Esplanade Theatre. The Glasgow indie institution, an intimate room. CONCERT · ON SALE
- 25 SEP** **Post Malone** — National Stadium. Stadium pop-rock, big production. CONCERT
- 27 SEP** **KARD** — the co-ed K-pop group on tour. CONCERT
- 2–3 OCT** **The Weeknd — After Hours Til Dawn** — National Stadium. CONCERT · TWO NIGHTS
- 7 OCT** **Hans Zimmer Live — The Next Level** — Indoor Stadium. His first SG show since 2019; Dune, Interstellar, Dark Knight. CONCERT · MARQUEE
- 9–11 OCT** **★ F1 Singapore Grand Prix — with the first-ever Sprint** — Marina Bay Street Circuit. Trackside concerts across the weekend. SPORT · THE SEASON'S MARQUEE
- 17 OCT** **BIGBANG 2026 World Tour** — National Stadium. CONCERT · ON SALE
- to 18 Oct** **"Art Remembers"** — National Gallery Singapore (also *When Art Meets Nature*, to 1 Nov). EXHIBITION
- from mid-Nov** **Christmas on A Great Street** — Orchard Road light-up and Gardens by the Bay's year-end display return; the family standing date. SEASON · FREE
- Nov** **Deepavali, Little India** — the Serangoon Road light-up and bazaar; a walkable evening before the crowds peak. FESTIVAL · FREE

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

- 10–11 Nov** **Jason Mraz** — Tokyo Garden Theater. An easy add-on to an autumn Tokyo trip. CONCERT · TOKYO
- 8–22 NOV** **★ Kyushu Basho (Grand Sumo)** — Fukuoka Kokusai Center. Tickets on sale 19 Sep — they move fast. SPORT · FUKUOKA
- Nov–Dec** **Autumn kōyō, Kyoto & Tokyo** — peak leaf-viewing windows; the ryokan rooms book months out. SEASON · PLAN AHEAD
- 2 SEP** **Venice Film Festival opens** — Danny Boyle's *Ink* (to 12 Sep); one to watch the wires for. FILM · VENICE

PLANNING NOTES

Setting the record straight. No.88's Diary listed "Oasis, Tokyo, 25–26 Oct." Those Tokyo Dome dates were October 2025 and have passed; there is no confirmed Oasis Japan date for 2026. The line was wrong, and this corrects it.¹

The F1 squeeze. With a Sprint added, the 9–11 Oct weekend is denser than ever — hotels near Marina Bay and the trackside concert passes are the things to lock first.²

Sumo timing. Kyushu Basho tickets open 19 Sep; the good seats for the second week go within the day.²

Kōyō, if you're chasing leaves. Kyoto and Tokyo peak late November into early December; the ryokan rooms that matter book months ahead, so a mid-Sept decision is not early.²

The soft-yen footnote. The yen near 160 (p14) keeps a Japan trip cheaper in Singapore-dollar terms than it has been in years — the currency, not the calendar, is the argument for going now.²

SOURCES 1. Songkick; oasis-live.net — no confirmed Oasis Japan 2026 date; the Tokyo Dome shows were Oct 2025 (correction to No.88). 2. Songkick; Ticketmaster; Sports Hub; sumo.or.jp; National Gallery Singapore — event dates and on-sale windows as listed; verify at booking.

THE DIARY • THE TABLE

A Michelin Hand Cooking Trattoria for Fifty-Eight Dollars

Singapore's newest openings, researched for whether they earn the trip: a starred chef's degustation whose reviews are now in, a New York bakery landing on Orchard, and a bagel counter hiding in an office block.

The reviews are in on the month's most pedigreed opening, and they land where the early word pointed. Assaggi (77A Neil Road) is Denis Lucchi — who has held Buona Terra's Michelin star since 2019 — going the other way: a set-menu-only Italian degustation that trades white-tablecloth polish for instinct, under the literal tagline "imperfect by choice."¹ The format is disarmingly accessible for the hand behind it — a three-course lunch at S\$58++, two dinner tasting menus at S\$88++ — and the trade read, from HungryGoWhere to The Ranting Panda, has settled near-unanimously warm: a Michelin-level kitchen at trattoria money. The honest caveat is the room. Set-menu-only, closed Sunday and Monday, and a small shophouse that will tighten fast — reserve the S\$88 dinner before the Buona Terra crowd catches on.

On Orchard, the pull is nostalgia with a pretzel. The City Bakery — the New York café that made the pretzel croissant and the pudding-thick hot chocolate famous — opened its first Singapore outlet at Mandarin Gallery on 13 August, its first in Southeast Asia.² Honesty first: the original Union Square store closed in 2019, so this arrives through the brand's Asian franchise network rather than under founder Maury Rubin's hand — take the heritage line with that caveat. The pretzel croissant (~S\$5) and the hot chocolate (~S\$8.70) are the draw; the wider mall-restaurant menu, by the trade read (Eatbook; The Ranting Panda ~3.5 of 5), is competent rather than revelatory, with a genuine quirk that bakery-counter items cannot be eaten in the restaurant seating. Promising, early days.

And the month's hidden-gem story is a bagel counter in an office block. Kali Kali, a stall in the CT Hub2 food court on Lavender Street, bakes bagels in-house with a crackly, buttery shio-pan-style crust over a

dense, chewy crumb — the Avo & Lox and a Bagel & Schmear set the signatures, from about S\$4.³ SETHLUI and Eatbook both put it in their August round-ups, and the novelty of a proper bagel bakery hidden in a foodcourt has done the rest; the one honest dissent is texture, the crumb reading as hearty to some and heavy to others. Too new for a settled verdict — go early on a weekday, before the office crowd clears the morning bake.

S\$58

ASSAGGI'S THREE-COURSE LUNCH — A MICHELIN-STARRED CHEF'S DEGUSTATION AT TRATTORIA MONEY¹

THE CHATTER • WHAT THE FOOD DESKS ACTUALLY SAY

Assaggi is the consensus "book it now," its reviews now in and warm — the pedigree-to-price ratio the hook, the small room the warning. The City Bakery trades on name recognition more than a queue; Kali Kali is the crate-digger's find, buzzy on value and craft. The running local note is that the shophouse and the foodcourt stall will both get harder to reach as the enthusiasm circulates.

HungryGoWhere; Eatbook; The Ranting Panda; SETHLUI — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • TOO NEW TO CROWN

Two of the three have been open days, not months, and the honest desk says so: opening press is enthusiasm, not a verdict. Assaggi has the settled reviews that earn its lead; the bakery and the bagel counter are provisional, and a season decides whether the novelty holds. A small factual caution too — verify the City Bakery's franchise pedigree and Kali Kali's opening hours before you make the trip.

MERIDIAN editorial standard — too-new-to-call

ITALIAN DEGUSTATION

NYC BAKERY

BENDEMEER BAGELS

SOURCES 1. HungryGoWhere; The Ranting Panda; middleclass.sg — Assaggi (Neil Rd), Denis Lucchi (Buona Terra*, since 2019), set-menu only, lunch S\$58++ / dinners S\$88++, opened 10 Aug 2026, reviews now settled. 2. Eatbook; The Ranting Panda; Mandarin Gallery directory — The City Bakery, Mandarin Gallery #02-11, opened 13 Aug 2026 (NYC brand via Asian franchise; Union Square original closed 2019 — verify franchisee), pretzel croissant ~S\$5 / hot chocolate ~S\$8.70. 3. Eatbook; SETHLUI — Kali Kali, CT Hub2 #01-68, Lavender St, opened Aug 2026, in-house bagels from ~S\$4; hours vary by source, verify. Prices indicative; verify at booking.

THE LONG READ · THE UNDERCURRENT — INDONESIA

The Crowd That Rarely Buys

Walk into a Jakarta mall on a Saturday and it looks like a boom. Look for the shopping bags and there aren't any. Indonesia has invented a comic vocabulary for the gap between the two — and it has become the country's most trusted economic indicator, precisely because no ministry issued it.

The escalators are packed, the food courts full, the queues for photographs long. Then you look at what people are carrying, and the hands are empty. Indonesians noticed this before their economists did, and they did what a society does when the official dashboard stops describing its life: they built their own, out of jokes. The core term went viral on TikTok and X from July 2025 and is still circulating in 2026 — *Rojali*, short for *Rombongan Jarang Beli*, "the group that rarely buys."¹

It has a whole family now. *Rohana* — *Rombongan Hanya Nanya*, "the group that only asks." *Rohalus* — the group that only looks, or only strokes the merchandise. *Robeli*, the rare group that actually buys.¹ What began as merchants mocking browsers who touch everything and buy nothing has been reclaimed by the browsers themselves as self-deprecating solidarity: *I'm proudly Rojali this month*. The Jakarta Post ran the phenomenon under a headline that is the whole essay in seven words — "Malls are full, but shopping bags are empty."²

"Malls are full, but shopping bags are empty." A country wrote its own economic report, and it fit in a headline.

Underneath the joke are hard numbers. Bank Indonesia's Real Sales Index fell about 3 per cent year-on-year in June 2026, the decline concentrated in the discretionary categories — fashion, electronics.³ Food and gold prices dragged the country into outright deflation in July, a symptom of weak demand rather than tamed prices. And the structural number is the one that stings: per the national statistics agency, the middle class shrank

from 57.33 million in 2019 to 47.85 million in 2024, and to about 46.7 million in 2025 — a fall that is accelerating, with roughly ten million people gone from the middle class in six years while the "aspiring middle class" below it swelled by millions more.³

~10m

PEOPLE GONE FROM INDONESIA'S MIDDLE CLASS SINCE 2019 — EVEN AS HEADLINE GDP KEEPS PRINTING ABOVE 5%³

And yet the headline looks fine. GDP grew 5.29 per cent in the second quarter of 2026 and 5.61 in the first — but the University of Indonesia's LPEM titled its own quarterly report "Growth Disguises a Weak Economy," noting the first-quarter surge leaned on a 21.8 per cent jump in government spending plus the Eid season and the civil-servants' thirteenth-month pay, not on private demand.⁴ A targeted sweep of the Western press turns up no NYT, BBC, Reuters or FT feature on Rojali as a cultural-economic story; the wires have touched Indonesian purchasing power only as dry macro items. The slang, the taxonomy, and what they reveal remain unexported — which is exactly why they belong here.

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE MONEY ACTUALLY GOES

Three lived explanations recur across Republika, CNA Indonesia and Kompas TV. The mall has become a free, air-conditioned living room — you go for the Wi-Fi, the cinema, the *nongkrong*, the photos. Showrooming: inspect in-store, buy the identical item cheaper on TikTok Shop or Shopee. And defensive saving — the rupiah that doesn't become a T-shirt becomes a gram of gold or a government bond. CNA Indonesia links the empty baskets directly to money flowing into gold and SBN.

Republika; CNA Indonesia; Kompas TV — characterised

SOURCES 1. Tirto; Tempo; CNBC Indonesia (28 Jul 2025) — the Rojali/Rohana/Rohalus/Robeli taxonomy, viral since July 2025, still circulating 2026. 2. The Jakarta Post, 29 Jul 2025 — "Malls are full, but shopping bags are empty." 3. BPS via Databoks/Katadata & Kontan (middle class 57.33m → 47.85m → ~46.7m); indonesia-investments (BI Real Sales Index --3% y/y June 2026); LPEM UI (July deflation) — primary BI figure flagged for verification. 4. indonesia-investments; LPEM UI ("Growth Disguises a Weak Economy," Q1 govt spending +21.8%) — GDP 5.29% Q2 / 5.61% Q1 2026.

THE LONG READ · THE ARGUMENT

A K-Shaped Economy, Laughed Off

Rojali is not proof that Indonesians are broke. It is the sound of a society bridging, with a joke, the distance between the statistics a state governs by and the life its citizens live inside.

The deepest thing here is not poverty; plenty of Indonesians are doing fine. It is the widening gap between the numbers a state governs by and the experience its people live inside. Jakarta can truthfully announce 5.3 per cent growth; the crowd in Grand Indonesia can just as truthfully report that nobody they know is buying anything. Both are real. Rojali is the vernacular bridge across that gap — a folk index invented by ordinary people because the official ones stopped describing their lives.¹

It matters for three reasons. First, it exposes the hollowness of the headline: a GDP figure propped up by government spending and a mall inflated by footfall are the same illusion at two scales — motion mistaken for prosperity. Second, it reveals a middle class turning defensive. Ten million people out of the bracket since 2019, the decline accelerating, means millions have *turun kelas*, slipped down a rung — and Rojali is the choreography of the newly precarious: still performing middle-class life, the mall visit, the latte, the nice photos, while quietly refusing the middle-class purchase.² The empty basket is dignity management — you keep the appearance of belonging while defending your cash.

Consumption theatre as a hedge against status loss: keep the appearance of belonging, and quietly defend the cash.

Third, it marks a platform-driven decoupling of desire from place. For thirty years the mall was Indonesia's cathedral of aspiration, the proof of a modernising nation. TikTok Shop severed the ritual: desire is discovered in physical space and consummated on a phone, at a lower price. The mall

has been demoted from marketplace to showroom and social club — not only weak purchasing power, but the physical retail estate of an entire economy being repriced in real time by the accessible-internet generation.³

+21.8%

THE JUMP IN GOVERNMENT SPENDING THAT LIFTED Q1 GDP — THE STATE, NOT THE SHOPPER, DOING THE BUYING¹

There is a lineage for this. Alan Greenspan watched men's-underwear sales; the "lipstick index" read small indulgences in a downturn; Japan counted neckties. Societies under stress reach for homemade, legible proxies when they distrust the dashboard. What is genuinely 2026 about Rojali is that the folk index is now content — crowd-sourced, comedic, and self-applied. It is an economic indicator that is also an identity you can claim ("I'm a Rojali") and a meme you can share.³ China's *tang ping* and consumption-downgrade were its resigned cousin; Rojali is the warmer, more communal version — the downgrade turned into a group outing.

THE SCEPTIC · MAYBE IT'S JUST CHANNEL-SHIFT

The government's own line is the sharpest rebuttal, and it deserves airing. Deputy Trade Minister Dyah Roro Esti dismissed the purchasing-power reading outright: "Our shopping habits have changed, and there's nothing wrong with that." The mall operators' association agrees window-shopping is decades old. The steel-man: if the money is moving to TikTok Shop and to gold rather than evaporating, aggregate consumption is fine — it has just left the mall. The honest read is that it is both, channel-shift and distress at once — but nobody memes a healthy economy into a mascot.

ANTARA (Wamendag Dyah Roro Esti); APPBI — characterised

SOURCES 1. LPEM UI; Prakarsa ("pseudo-growth amid weak purchasing power"); indonesia-investments — Q1 government spending +21.8%; the growth-vs-experience gap. 2. BPS via Databoks/Kontan — middle-class decline and *turun kelas*; the "aspiring middle class" swelling. 3. CNA Indonesia; ResearchGate (academic paper on the Rojali/Rohana phenomenon, 2025) — showrooming, defensive saving into gold/SBN, the folk-index tradition.

THE LONG READ · WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

The Test the Next Data Release Will Run

A thesis is only honest if it names what would falsify it. Rojali's does — and the answer, when it comes, will be read in a folk vocabulary no ministry can retire by decree.

What would prove the benign reading right: e-commerce growth large enough to fully offset the physical-retail contraction, so that total real consumption is flat or rising and this is pure channel-shift; the middle-class decline reversing in the next BPS release; the Real Sales Index turning positive year-on-year through late 2026.¹ What would prove the darker reading: deflation persisting, layoffs climbing, and the "aspiring middle class" continuing to swell at the middle class's expense. The virtue of the slang is that it forces the question into the open, in a language the country actually speaks.

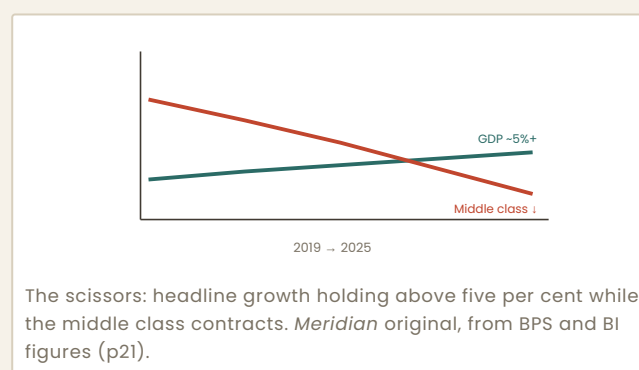
The tell is not really in any single number; it is in who gets to name reality. A government can announce growth, and be arithmetically correct, and still lose the argument about what the economy *feels* like — because the citizens have coined a word that captures the receipt in their hand better than the figure on the podium. When the official index and the folk index disagree, the folk one wins the culture, whatever the statisticians say. That is the return of Philip K. Dick's definition from the front of this issue: reality is what doesn't go away when you stop believing the label. The empty basket does not go away because a minister says the habit merely changed.²

When the official index and the folk index disagree, the folk one wins the culture — whatever the statisticians decide.

For the reader watching from Singapore, the practical read is a regional one. Indonesia is the largest consumer market in Southeast Asia, and a defensive, downgrading middle class there is a signal that travels — through the NODX numbers, through

the regional retailers, through the same TikTok Shop economics now reshaping every mall from Jakarta to Jurong.² The Vietnamese version of the story is already visible in the young buying gold by the gram. The vocabulary will differ; the undercurrent — a generation quietly hedging against a future its governments keep describing as bright — is the same. Watch the folk indices. They are usually early.

There is also a warning here for anyone who reads economies through dashboards, this magazine's Macro Desk included. A headline number is a compression, and compression discards exactly the texture — who is spending, who is retreating, what the money is afraid of — that a folk index like Rojali preserves. The lesson is not to distrust the statistics; it is to read them against the receipts, and to notice when a whole society starts keeping its own books because the official ones no longer reconcile with the day. That noticing is the reader's edge, in a mall in Jakarta or a portfolio in Singapore.¹



Rojali will fade as a meme; folk indices always do. But the thing it names will not fade on the same schedule, and the next one is already being coined somewhere on a Jakarta feed. A country that has to invent a mascot for its own recession is a country whose institutions have lost the franchise on describing it — and that, more than any single quarter's print, is the story the wires will write up in three weeks' time.

SOURCES 1. Falsification tests — BPS middle-class series; BI Real Sales Index; e-commerce GMV vs physical-retail contraction (the channel-shift steel-man). 2. Regional read — CNA Indonesia (gold/SBN flows); World Gold Council Q2-2026 (Vietnam young gold-buyers, the regional rhyme); SCMP ("Indonesia's economy is up, so why are its people down?"). Sentiment characterised; single-authority figures flagged in p21-22.

THE LAST WORD

On the Distance Between the Number and the Receipt

A country can announce five per cent growth and be right, and its citizens can fill the malls and buy nothing and be right too, and the gap between those two truths is where this whole issue lived. A belt sold as "genuine leather" that means the opposite. A record labelled "all-analog" cut from a digital file. A strike a defence ministry says never landed. An age you can declare but not prove. Reality, said the man whose line opened the book, is that which doesn't go away when you stop believing in it — and the useful corollary this week is its twin: the label goes away the moment you check it against the thing. The reader's whole discipline, from the belt to the ballot to the balance sheet, is the checking. Keep the receipt.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES

The World: Washington Post; CNBC; Al Jazeera; Arab News; UAE defence ministry; TradingEconomics; Bloomberg; ABC News; IFRC. Singapore/Family: MDDI; AsiaOne; The Star/ANN; MTI; Mothership; Pew Research Center; Al Jazeera (eSafety); UC Irvine/Techdirt (Odgers, Przybylski). Atelier: Permanent Style; Styleforum; Gentleman's Gazette; maker listings (Hanks, Orion, Tanner Goods, Anderson's, Kobashi). Technology/Home Lab: DataCenterDynamics; CNBC; Nvidia results; Unsloth; local-ai-zone. The Kit/Good Life: TechPowerUp; Notebookcheck; Engadget; Gear Patrol; What Hi-Fi. Screen & Sound: Cartoon Brew; Screen Daily; Deadline; Consequence. Macro: Yahoo Finance; CNBC; Bloomberg; stockanalysis.com; growbeansprout.com; TradingEconomics. Rabbit Hole: RIAA; Billboard; Variety; AnalogPlanet; Music Direct; Rolling Stone; SoundGuys. Fitness: Nature Scientific Reports; Daily Burn; Attia; Huberman Lab. Diary: Songkick; sumo.or.jp; HungryGoWhere; The Ranting Panda; Ordinary Patrons. The Long Read: Tirta; Tempo; The Jakarta Post; BPS/Databoks; LPEM UI; indonesia-investments; CNA Indonesia; ANTARA. Full per-page footnotes appear on each desk. Market data is context, not investment advice; family and fitness content is general guidance, not medical advice.